

White-Lined Gecko / Skunk Gecko (*Gekko vittatus*)

Difficulty: Intermediate

White-lined geckos, also called skunk geckos or lined geckos, are slender medium-sized geckos that usually reach about 8-10 inches total length. They are named for the pale stripe that begins behind the eyes, joins at the neck, and continues down the back. They are fast, strongly arboreal, often vocal, and usually better suited to display-focused keepers than to frequent handling. Because published longevity data are limited, plan for a long commitment of roughly 10-15+ years rather than treating them as a short-lived pet.

Gekko vittatus occurs across parts of Indonesia, New Guinea, Palau/Belau, the Bismarck and Solomon archipelagos, and other western Pacific islands. Field accounts describe a nocturnal gecko using smooth tree branches, palms, banana plants, and sometimes buildings. Species-specific husbandry research is limited, so the recommendations below combine documented natural history with conservative modern standards for nocturnal arboreal geckos: generous vertical space, usable thermal and humidity gradients, low-level UVB, varied invertebrate prey, and single housing as the safest default.

Shopping List

- Front-opening vertical enclosure, minimum 18" x 18" x 36" for one adult; larger is preferred
- Secure locking doors and a well-ventilated screen top; this species is fast and an excellent climber
- Low-wattage white/clear halogen or incandescent basking bulb
- Dimming thermostat or proportional thermostat for heat control
- Low-output linear UVB fixture appropriate for Ferguson Zone 1
- Plug-in light timer
- Digital probe thermometer/hygrometer and infrared temperature gun
- Pressure sprayer or automatic misting system
- Reptile-safe water conditioner if using chlorinated or chloraminated tap water
- 2-4" tropical substrate; drainage layer and screen separator if bioactive
- Clean leaf litter
- Sturdy cork tubes/flats, branches, vines, ledges, and dense live or artificial foliage
- Small elevated water dish or secure wall-mounted cup
- Appropriately sized crickets, roaches, black soldier fly larvae, silkworms, hornworms, or similar feeders
- Calcium supplement and a reputable reptile multivitamin
- Feeding tongs and a digital gram scale for routine weight checks

Housing

White-lined geckos are active arboreal hunters and should not be kept in the old small-aquarium setups still repeated in some pet-store literature. For one adult, 18" x 18" x 36" should be treated as a practical minimum; 24" x 18" x 36", 24" x 24" x 36", or larger gives a better gradient and more usable climbing space. Healthy juveniles can use a well-furnished adult-sized enclosure as long as food intake, hydration, and stool output can be monitored.

The enclosure should be densely furnished rather than tall and empty. Build multiple routes from bottom to top with cork tubes, broad branches, vines, ledges, and foliage. Include vertical and diagonal surfaces as well as horizontal resting perches. Several tight, dark retreats are important because this species normally hides during the day. Use secure latches and check cable openings carefully; a startled white-lined gecko can move extremely quickly and squeeze through surprisingly small gaps.

A newly acquired gecko should be quarantined individually on paper towel until feeding, hydration, stool quality, and general health are established. Once stable, move to a naturalistic or bioactive enclosure if desired. Keep a shallow clean water source available even when the gecko regularly drinks droplets after misting.

Lighting & UVB

Although white-lined geckos are nocturnal, they still need a clear daytime light period. Use about a 12-hour day/night cycle, with complete darkness at night. Bright visible light for live plants is appropriate as long as the animal has deep shaded retreats and is never forced to remain exposed.

Low-level UVB is strongly recommended. There are no controlled UVB trials specific to *Gekko vittatus*, so a conservative Ferguson Zone 1 approach is appropriate: aim for about UVI 0.5-1.0 at the highest exposed

basking perch, while providing shaded areas near UVI 0. A maximum around 1.4 should not be exceeded without a species-specific reason. A low-output linear T5 fixture can work well when distance and mesh are accounted for. A Solarmeter 6.5 is the most reliable way to verify actual exposure.

Place UVB on the same side as the daytime heat source so heat, visible light, and UVB form one optional basking zone. Do not place glass or solid plastic between the lamp and the gecko because these materials block useful UVB. Avoid red, blue, purple, or other colored night bulbs; if overnight heat is ever required, use a lightless heat source on a thermostat.

Heating

Provide a gentle vertical thermal gradient with overhead daytime heat rather than heating the entire enclosure uniformly. A low-wattage halogen or incandescent lamp above one side of the enclosure allows the gecko to move between warmer upper perches and cooler shaded areas.

Warm basking branch / surface: 86-90°F (30-32°C)

General daytime air: 76-82°F (24-28°C)

Cool lower zone: 72-78°F (22-26°C)

Nighttime: 70-75°F (21-24°C)

Avoid sustained temperatures above about 92°F (33°C), especially when humidity is high and airflow is poor. Use a probe thermometer to measure air temperature and an infrared thermometer to check perch surfaces. Night heat is usually unnecessary in a typical home unless the enclosure consistently falls below about 68-70°F; if it is needed, use a thermostat-controlled ceramic heat emitter or similar lightless source.

Humidity

Humidity should cycle rather than remaining saturated all day. A useful target is roughly 55-70% during the drier daytime period, with an evening misting that temporarily raises humidity to about 75-90%. The enclosure should then ventilate and partially dry before the next heavy mist. Individual humid retreats inside cork tubes and dense foliage allow the gecko to choose a more humid microclimate without forcing the entire enclosure to stay wet.

Constant condensation, soggy substrate, stale air, or persistent heavy mold indicate excessive moisture or inadequate ventilation. Mist leaves, branches, and enclosure walls so droplets are available for drinking, but also provide a clean water cup and change it daily. Check toes and tail tip during sheds; retained skin is often a sign that the moisture gradient or hydration routine needs improvement.

Substrate

For an established animal, use 2-4 inches of a well-draining tropical substrate such as a pesticide- and fertilizer-free organic topsoil/coco blend, ReptiSoil-style mix, or ABG-type substrate, topped with clean leaf litter. Bioactive enclosures should have enough drainage capacity to handle repeated misting without leaving the lower soil waterlogged.

Paper towel is appropriate for quarantine, medical monitoring, or when stool must be closely observed. Avoid reptile carpet, pine or cedar products, large loose bark chunks, and other coarse materials that can trap toes or be difficult to pass if swallowed. Spot-clean feces and dead feeder insects promptly; refresh or replace non-bioactive substrate as it becomes soiled rather than waiting for odor or mold.

Food

White-lined geckos are primarily insectivorous. Offer a varied rotation of appropriately sized live invertebrates rather than relying on one feeder species. Good staples include crickets, dubia or discoid roaches, black soldier fly larvae, silkworms, and appropriately sized mealworms; hornworms can be used for variety and hydration. Large, very fatty feeders should be occasional rather than routine.

Juveniles: offer appropriately sized prey daily or nearly daily, adjusting to growth and body condition.

Adults: feed about every other day or roughly 3-4 times per week. Hard-bodied prey should generally be no wider than the space between the gecko's eyes. Remove uneaten insects that could bother the gecko while it rests.

Wild white-lined geckos may opportunistically take small vertebrates, but that does not make rodents or feeder lizards necessary in captivity. Routine vertebrate prey adds excess calories and avoidable risk. Crested gecko diet, fruit puree, and baby food should not be used as staple foods for this primarily insectivorous species.

Supplements

Gut-load feeder insects for about 24-48 hours before offering them. Most feeder insects have an unfavorable calcium-to-phosphorus ratio, so they should be lightly dusted. With correctly measured UVB, plain calcium or a low-D3 calcium product can be used on most juvenile meals and about every other adult meal, with a broad-spectrum reptile multivitamin used according to its label, commonly every 1-2 weeks.

If UVB is not provided, dietary vitamin D3 becomes more important, but supplementation is not a reason to stack several high-D3 or multivitamin products at once. Follow one coherent supplement schedule and adjust for the specific products being used. Adult females can have increased calcium demands during egg production, including when eggs are not intentionally being bred.

Decor

Decor is functional habitat for this species. Use cork rounds, cork flats, smooth sturdy branches, bamboo-sized perches, vines, ledges, broad leaves, and live or artificial plants to create covered routes through the whole enclosure. Hollow cork tubes are especially useful as secure daytime retreats. Provide several perch diameters and orientations so the gecko can climb, jump, hunt, hide, and choose among different temperatures and humidity levels.

Handling Tip: White-lined geckos are best treated as display animals. They can be fast, vocal, defensive, and capable of a firm bite when frightened. They may also drop the tail, which can regrow but is still a major stress event. Avoid grabbing from above or restraining the tail. For enclosure transfers, a cork tube, deli cup, or small transport container is often safer than hand-catching. If routine handling is attempted, keep sessions short and close to the ground.

Cohabitation

Single housing is the safest default. Captive breeders have reported successful pairs or groups, but this does not mean cohabitation is automatically low-stress, and the species can be territorial. Never house unfamiliar adults together simply because they are the same species, never keep two males together for routine pet housing, and do not mix substantially different sizes. Monitor any breeding introduction for chasing, bite wounds, tail damage, weight loss, persistent hiding, or food competition.

Females lay hard-shelled eggs that are commonly glued to bark, branches, cork, rock, or enclosure walls. Do not pry an attached egg loose; the shell can be damaged easily. If breeding occurs, incubate the egg where it is attached when practical or move the entire removable object. Breeding should be intentional, with a plan for separation and for raising offspring individually or in carefully managed grow-out housing.

RED ROCKS

EXOTIC REPTILES

— ★ ★ ★ ★ —